of religion, they give their lives for the wealth of this world and do not fear death'.[19] But the rebels certainly used the rhetoric of religious war in order to recruit for and justify their revolution – a relative innovation in the internal history of the Afghan peoples as most previous conflict had been between Muslims.[y] 'All the citizens, great and small, rich and poor, civilian and military, were made to swear on the Holy Qur'an to support the struggle,' adds Mohammad Husain Herati.[20]

The first targets of the newly strengthened rebels were the series of small outlying forts and tower houses between the town and cantonment that the British military bureaucrats had commandeered as storehouses. 'All these forts were close to the city,' wrote Herati, 'in a continuous web of orchard walls and irrigation channels, with thick tree-cover, which made it easy for the guerrillas to approach.'[21] There was nothing random about this choice of target: the rebel leaders were well aware that the British had failed to make proper arrangements for guarding their supplies which were stored not within the cantonment but at the forts of Jafar Khan, Nishan Khan and Mohammad Sharif.

> They realised that if they could destroy or capture these forts, the British would either die of hunger, or surrender from lack of ammunition, or both. Thus, as soon as Burnes was dead, they headed out of the city to destroy the forts and loot the godowns there. Within minutes, they pulled down the Fort Jafar Khan and set it on fire. Then they pushed forward to the Fort Mohammad Shareef which was adjacent to the Cantonment, and the Ghazis then turned their attention back to bringing down the walls, and like rats began to dig up the foundations.[22]

That morning, Captain Colin Mackenzie had woken in the third of the walled compounds to be targeted for attack, the Qal'a Nishan Khan, the commissariat fort reserved for the supplies of the Shah's forces. This fort, which contained nine months' supplies of wheat and fodder, as well as all the British medical supplies, lay just over a mile from the British headquarters, flanked by the canal and the Qizilbash quarter of Murad Khani on one side and on the other abutting the Shah Bagh. Mackenzie had already heard rumours of trouble in the town but was absorbed in adding up his regimental accounts, which he wanted to complete before accompanying the Envoy down to Peshawar the following day.

> Suddenly, a naked man stood before me, covered with blood, from two deep sabre cuts in the head and five musket shots in the arm and body. He proved to be a sawar [cavalryman] of Sir W Macnaghten sent with a message to us, but intercepted by the insurgents. This being a rather